

Abstract

This study examines how in-group and out-group partisan media exposure are associated with hostile media perceptions and the perceived credibility of broadcast network news, and whether these associations vary across levels of uncritical patriotism, drawing on a cross-sectional matched YouGov survey of U.S. adults ($N = 735$).

Why This Study

- Relatively balanced broadcast network news coverage, yet sharply divided audience credibility judgments.
- Existing accounts centered on selective exposure and hostile media perceptions do not fully explain within-party variation.
- Uncritical patriotism (UCP)**: unquestioning national attachment and comparatively low tolerance of national criticism.
- Tests whether UCP conditions exposure–HMP and indirect credibility associations.

Method

Measures (7-point scales unless noted; α)

- Partisan media exposure: in-group vs. out-group composites based on 6-point frequency items; focal composites standardized.
- Hostile media perceptions: 4 items, $\alpha = .88$.
- Credibility: 3 items, $\alpha = .95$.
- Uncritical patriotism: 4 items, $\alpha = .89$.
- Constructive patriotism: 4 items, $\alpha = .82$ (control).

Analysis

- 7 prespecified cross-sectional weighted OLS models.
- Johnson-Neyman probing across uncritical patriotism.
- Bootstrapped conditional indirect associations.
- Controls: constructive patriotism, network-news exposure, and standard demographic and political covariates.

N **N = 735**
406 Democrats/leaners · 329 Republicans/leaners

DATE **Nov. 2023**
Matched YouGov survey · original case weights

OLS **HC3**
Weighted OLS · robust SEs · 95% CIs

BOOT **10,000**
Pairs-bootstrap replications · all succeeded

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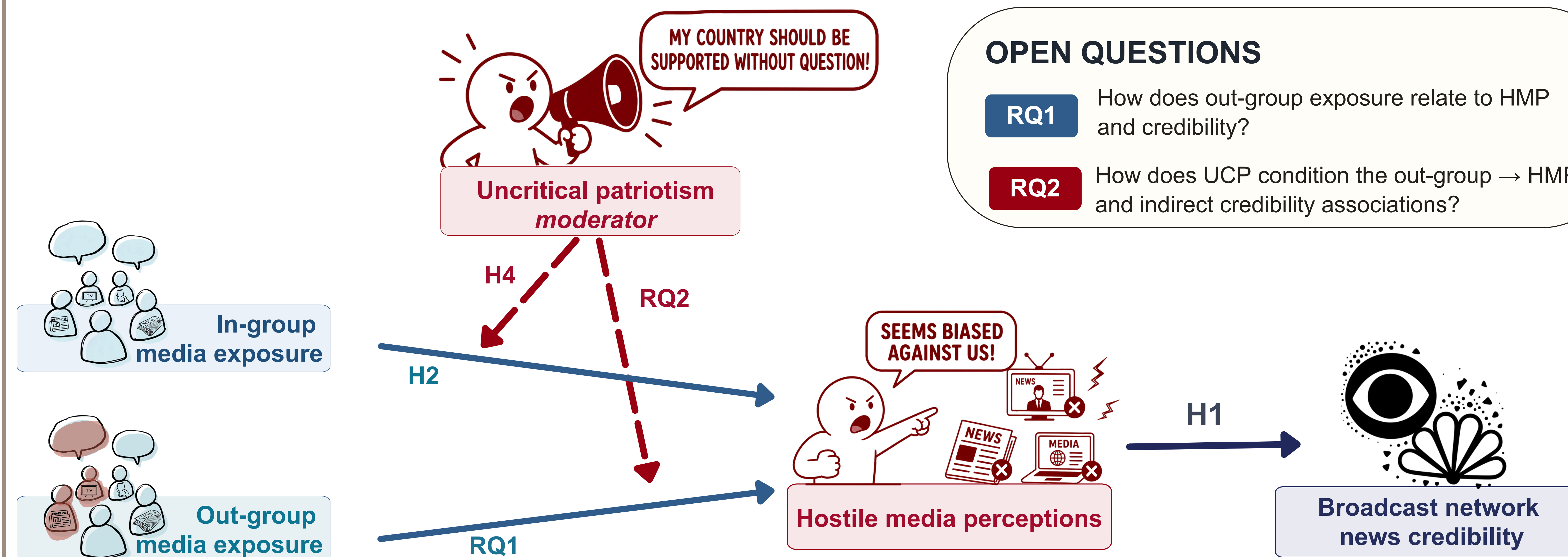
EXPECTED RELATIONSHIPS

H1 HMP → lower credibility

H2 In-group exposure → higher HMP

H3 / H5 In-group exposure → lower credibility, indirectly via HMP;
The in-group indirect link grows more negative as UCP rises

H4 Higher UCP strengthens the in-group → HMP link

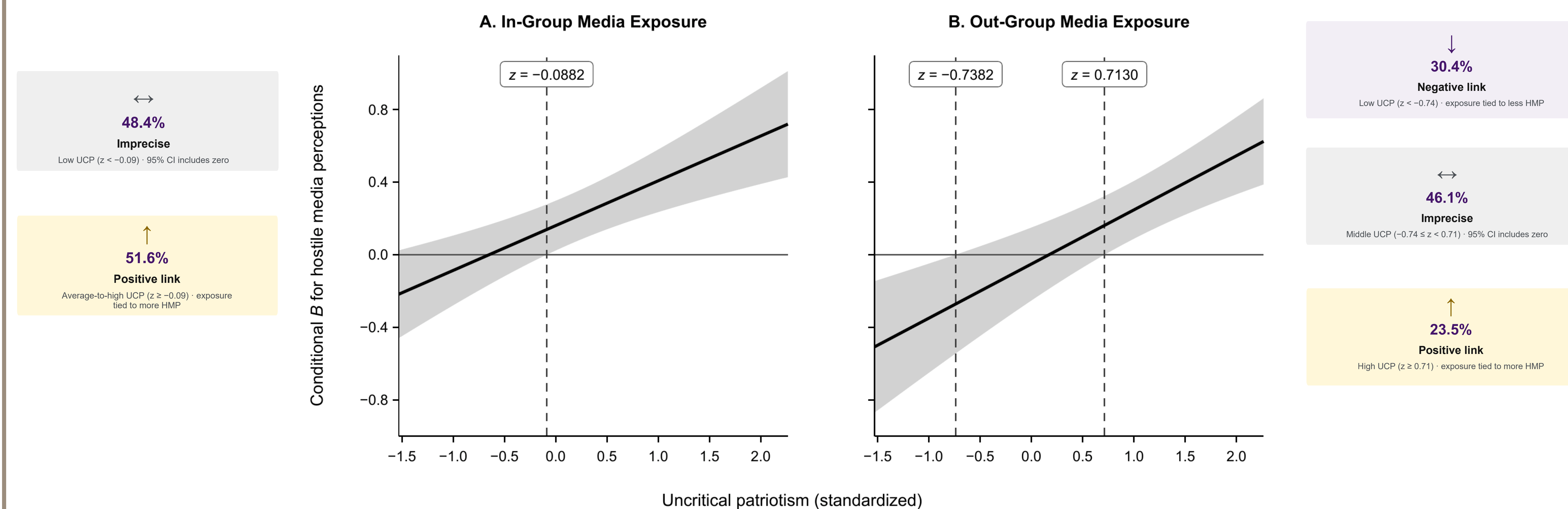


OPEN QUESTIONS

RQ1 How does out-group exposure relate to HMP and credibility?

RQ2 How does UCP condition the out-group → HMP and indirect credibility associations?

Moderation by Uncritical Patriotism



Note. Across the observed range, in-group exposure never turns significantly negative; only out-group exposure reverses direction, from negative at low patriotism to positive at high.

Key Results

Association	Estimate	95% CI	p	Finding
H1 HMP → Credibility	-0.32	[-0.41, -0.24]	< .001	Supported
H2 In-group → HMP	0.18	[0.04, 0.32]	.014	Supported
H4 In-group × UCP → HMP	0.25	[0.13, 0.37]	< .001	Supported
H3:	—	—	—	Qualified support
Low UCP ($z = -1$)	0.03	[-0.03, 0.09]	—	Imprecise
Average UCP ($z = 0$)	-0.05	[-0.10, -0.01]	—	Negative
High UCP ($z = +1$)	-0.13	[-0.20, -0.07]	—	Negative
H5 In-group index of moderated indirect association	-0.08	[-0.13, -0.04]	—	Provisional ^a
RQ1 Out-group → HMP	0.16	[-0.01, 0.33]	.063	Statistically imprecise (average)
RQ1 Out-group → Credibility, Model A (UCP $z = 0$)	0.29	[0.09, 0.50]	.005	Positive
RQ2 Out-group × UCP → HMP	0.30	[0.17, 0.43]	< .001	Moderated
RQ2 Out-group indirect (index)	-0.11	[-0.16, -0.05]	—	Moderated

Note. $N = 735$. Weighted OLS with HC3 SEs; focal predictors standardized. Conditional indirect associations and indices use 95% percentile bootstrap CIs (10,000 draws); no bootstrap p values were computed. H1 is shown for the in-group specification; the HMP–credibility association was also negative in the out-group specification ($B = -0.35$, $p < .001$). ^a Specification-sensitive: the corresponding jointly adjusted index was -0.040 , 95% percentile bootstrap CI [-0.089, 0.006].

Discussion Highlights

Extends hostile media perceptions research beyond partisanship by framing national loyalty as an evaluative standard associated with whether critical reporting is perceived as legitimate scrutiny or an identity-relevant threat.

Connects stronger hostile media perceptions with lower perceived credibility of broadcast network news.

Reveals a conditional out-group pattern: the media–HMP association was negative at low UCP, statistically imprecise at middle levels, and positive at high UCP.

Qualifies the in-group contribution: H4 was supported and H5 received provisional support under the separate-interaction specification, but both conclusions were specification-sensitive.

Cross-sectional associations; no direct cross-specification difference test was conducted.

In One Sentence

Out-group media exposure was associated with lower HMP at low UCP but higher HMP at high UCP, highlighting uncritical patriotism as an important boundary condition for this association.